Source credibility

Source credibility refers to **the perceived trustworthiness, competence, and goodwill of a person or entity**. It is a powerful form of social influence where individuals are more likely to follow or believe information from credible sources compared to less credible ones.

Source Credibility: How To Select the Best Sources

Finding sources for research is important, but using unreliable sources will hurt your credibility and make your arguments seem less powerful. It is important to be able to identify which sources are credible. This ability requires an understanding of depth, objectivity, currency, authority, and purpose.

Whether or not your source is peer-reviewed, it is still a good idea to evaluate it based on the above five factors. An article that has been peer-reviewed is credible, but it still might not be completely relevant to your assignment.

Depth

What is the depth of coverage of the information? A source that is completely reliable may still only give a light overview of the important information. In many cases, you will need to have more than a simple overview of information in order to connect the data to your topic.

Objectivity

Is the information you are using biased in any way? If so, does the bias affect the conclusions of the research? Does the information come from a source that will profit from a particular point of view? If so, the information may not be reliable. Does the source use proper citation?

Currency

How up-to-date is the information? When was it written?

Many assignments, especially in the sciences, require
research from the past five or ten years.

Authority

Who is the author? Does the author have a degree in the field? Is the author affiliated with an unbiased reputable organization? Note that scholarly articles tend to have multiple authors.

Purpose

What is the purpose of the source? Is it to entertain, to change public opinion, to present research, or to teach? Who is the intended audience? Reliable research articles are usually very specific in nature and relate to a very specific field.

Bias detection

"Bias detection in critical and creative thinking" refers to the process of identifying and actively recognizing personal biases that can influence one's ability to analyze information objectively and generate creative solutions, requiring a conscious effort to challenge assumptions and consider diverse perspectives to avoid skewed conclusions.

Key points about bias detection in critical and creative thinking:

Understanding common biases:

To effectively detect bias, one must first be familiar with various cognitive biases like confirmation bias, anchoring bias, availability heuristic, in-group bias, and more.

Self-reflection and introspection:

Regularly examining one's own thoughts and reactions to situations is crucial to identify potential biases that may be influencing decision-making.

Seeking diverse perspectives:

Actively seeking out viewpoints that differ from your own can help challenge existing biases and broaden your understanding of a topic.

Critical questioning:

Asking probing questions about the source of information, underlying assumptions, and potential biases within arguments can help identify biased thinking.

Challenge assumptions:

Be mindful of assumptions you might be making and actively challenge them to avoid biased conclusions.

How bias can affect critical and creative thinking:

Limited exploration of ideas:

Confirmation bias can lead to only considering information that supports pre-existing beliefs, hindering the generation of new and innovative solutions.

Overlooking potential solutions:

Anchoring bias can cause individuals to overly rely on initial information, potentially missing better options.

Groupthink:

When individuals prioritize conformity within a group, it can stifle critical thinking and diverse perspectives.

Strategies to mitigate bias in critical and creative thinking:

Devil's advocate:

Deliberately argue against your own position to identify potential flaws in your reasoning.

Blind review process:

When evaluating ideas, anonymize submissions to reduce bias based on personal characteristics.

Diversity in teams:

Foster teams with diverse backgrounds and experiences to encourage a broader range of perspectives.

Explicit bias training:

Participate in training programs designed to raise awareness of common biases and strategies to overcome them.

Evidence-based thinking

Evidence-based thinking is a process that involves using current knowledge to align beliefs. It's a way to make decisions and judgments based on evidence and reason, rather than emotion or anecdote.

How it's used

- In education, evidence-based strategies include assessing prior knowledge, setting clear learning goals, and providing feedback
- In healthcare, evidence-based practice includes checking blood pressure readings and reducing unnecessary prescriptions
- In business, evidence-based decision-making can help organizations decide whether to implement new policies

Benefits of evidence-based thinking

- It can help people filter information and reach a common understanding of challenges
- It can help people make objective judgments
- It can help people resist claims that lack support
- It can help people make decisions that are based on the best available evidence

Challenges of evidence-based thinking

There may be behavioral, social, or methodological challenges to apply evidence-based thinking. However, pragmatic strategies can be used to overcome these challenges.